

SOCIETY · DEMOCRACY

Should the state make you vote?

For most Brazilians, voting isn't a choice: it's the law. Most democracies let people decide. Who has it right?

NAME

DATE

THE EXERCISES MATCH THE ONLINE PAGE

158.7m

Brazilians able to vote in 2026

21countries with compulsory voting;
about 10 enforce it**R\$ 3.51**

maximum fine per round missed

20.95%stayed home in the first round of
2022

On Sunday 4 October, 158.7 million Brazilians are able to vote for president, governors and Congress. For most of them, turning up¹ is not optional. Brazil is one of only 21 countries in the world with compulsory voting, and one of about ten that actually enforce it².

WHAT THE LAW ASKS

If you are between 18 and 70, the law requires you to vote. If you are 16 or 17, over 70, or cannot read, it lets you choose. The fine for staying at home³ is tiny: up to R\$ 3.51 for each round you miss.

The real cost⁴ comes later. Until you justify your absence⁵ or pay the fine, the state won't let you get a passport, sign up for a public-sector exam⁶ or enrol⁷ at a public university.

And yet millions stay home anyway. In the first round of 2022, 20.95% of voters didn't show up⁸: more than 32 million people. Some forgot, some were travelling, and some simply refused to let the government tell them what to do.

A RARE RULE

Most democracies let citizens decide for themselves. Where voting is compulsory, the history is long. Belgium introduced the rule in 1893, and Australia in 1924. Today Australia sends non-voters a fine of AU\$20, and turnout⁹ rarely falls below¹⁰ 90%.

Belgium is moving the other way. The country stopped punishing non-voters in 2003, and in 2024 the Flemish region no longer made people vote in local elections.

“When Chile let people choose, turnout fell to 43%.”

Chile, 2021 · voluntary voting

THE CHILEAN EXPERIMENT

Chile offers the clearest test. In 2012 it let citizens choose, and turnout collapsed¹¹: in 2021, only 43% of registered voters took part¹². Worried that a small, angry minority was deciding for everyone, the country made voting compulsory again in 2022. In the constitutional referendum that September, turnout jumped to 85.8%. Venezuela went the opposite way in 1993, and turnout fell from 82% to 61%.

DUTY OR FREEDOM?

Supporters say the rule forces politicians to listen to everyone, not only to the most motivated¹³ voters. When everybody votes, a party can't win just by getting its angriest fans to the polls¹⁴. They also argue that it protects poorer citizens, who are usually the first to stay home when voting is optional.

Critics see it differently. Freedom, they say, includes the freedom not to take part. They warn that forcing uninterested people to vote produces random votes, or votes for sale¹⁵. Some suggest that Brazil keep the duty¹⁶ to register¹⁷ but let each voter decide whether to turn up.

On Sunday, most Brazilians will vote because they have to. The real question is whether they would go if nobody made them.

Sources: TSE (2026 electorate); Senado Notícias (dates and fine); IFES (penalties); Rio Times (2022 abstention); International IDEA and Wikipedia, "Compulsory voting" (other countries).

CHUNKS FROM THE ARTICLE Os números batem com as palavras sublinhadas no texto

1 turning up comparecer	2 enforce it fazem valer a regra	3 staying at home ficar em casa (não votar)
4 real cost o custo de verdade	5 justify your absence justificar a ausência	6 sign up for a public-sector exam se inscrever em concurso público
7 enrol se matricular	8 show up aparecer, comparecer	9 turnout comparecimento
10 falls below fica abaixo de	11 collapsed despencou	12 took part participaram
13 motivated engajados, motivados	14 polls urnas	15 for sale à venda
16 duty dever	17 register se alistar como eleitor	

COMMENTS 6 readers · fictional voices for this lesson

RM	Rafael M. · São Paulo Nobody should make me vote. I pay my taxes and I follow the law. Freedom also means the freedom to stay home. For once, I'd like the government to trust its citizens.
HL	Helena L. · replying to Rafael Trust works both ways, Rafael. If voting were optional, only the angriest people would turn up. I want everyone to have a say, not just the loudest. Don't stay home on Sunday.
MT	Marcos T. · Recife · teacher Making people vote doesn't make them informed. Half my students vote for whoever their parents tell them to. I want the government to teach young people to understand politics, not just push them to the polls.
JK	Júlia K. · replying to Marcos In Chile they let people choose and turnout fell to 43%. Don't let a minority decide for everyone, Marcos. Informed or not, every vote counts the same.
AP	Ana P. · Curitiba I'm 72, so the law lets me stay home now. I still go. My parents spent years unable to choose their own president. Nobody needs to make me vote.
PR	Paulo R. · Manaus A fine of R\$ 3.51? That's not a rule, it's a suggestion. You should pay it before you travel, though, or they won't let you get a passport.

Same numbers as the online page. Os números batem com a página da aula.

1 True or false?

Verdadeiro ou falso?

Read the sentence. Is it true, according to the article? Circle T or F.

Se for falso, corrija na linha com o que o texto diz.

Example Belgium still punishes people who don't vote.

T **F**

Procure Belgium no texto: "stopped punishing non-voters in 2003". A frase diz o contrário.

Belgium stopped punishing non-voters in 2003.

YOUR TURN · agora é você

1 The law requires Brazilians aged 18 to 70 to vote.

T **F**

IF IT'S FALSE · se for falso, corrija

2 The law makes 16- and 17-year-olds vote.

T **F**

IF IT'S FALSE · se for falso, corrija

3 Most democracies make their citizens vote.

T **F**

IF IT'S FALSE · se for falso, corrija

4 Australia sends non-voters a fine.

T **F**

IF IT'S FALSE · se for falso, corrija

5 When Chile let people choose, turnout went up.

T **F**

IF IT'S FALSE · se for falso, corrija

6 Until non-voters justify their absence, the state won't let them get a passport.

T **F**

IF IT'S FALSE · se for falso, corrija

7 Some critics suggest that Brazil keep the duty to register.

T **F**

IF IT'S FALSE · se for falso, corrija

8 In 2022, almost everyone obeyed the law and voted.

T **F**

IF IT'S FALSE · se for falso, corrija

2 Ask and answer

Pergunte e responda

Use the words. Write the question and the answer.

A estrutura não muda na pergunta: **let / make** + pessoa + verbo; **want / force** + pessoa + **to**.

Example What / Australia / make / non-voters / pay

Make é Família 2: make + pessoa + verbo, sem to. Na pergunta entra does, e make fica na base.

QUESTION · pergunta

What does Australia make non-voters pay?

ANSWER · resposta

It makes them pay a fine of AU\$20.

YOUR TURN · agora é você

1 What / the law / let / people over 70 / do

QUESTION · pergunta

ANSWER · resposta

2 What / the state / not let / non-voters / do

QUESTION · pergunta

ANSWER · resposta

3 What / Chile / make / citizens / do / again in 2022

QUESTION · pergunta

ANSWER · resposta

4 What / the rule / force / politicians / do

QUESTION · pergunta

ANSWER · resposta

5 What / some critics / suggest / that Brazil / do

QUESTION · pergunta

ANSWER · resposta

6 What / Rafael / would like / the government / do

QUESTION · pergunta

ANSWER · resposta

3 What did they say?

Conte o que os leitores disseram

Report it. Use the verb in brackets.

O pedido vira **verb + pessoa + to**; o “não faça” vira **not to**; recommend pede **that**.

Example Rafael to the government: “Trust your citizens.” (ask)

Ask é Família 1: ask + pessoa + to. Your citizens vira its citizens.

Rafael asked the government to trust its citizens.

YOUR TURN · agora é você

1 Helena to Rafael: “Don’t stay home on Sunday.” (tell)

2 Marcos to the government: “Teach young people to understand politics.” (want)

3 Ana to her grandchildren: “Please go and vote, even if it’s optional for you.” (ask)

4 Paulo to his friends: “You should pay the fine before you travel.” (advise)

5 Júlia to Marcos: “Don’t let a minority decide for everyone.” (warn)

6 Helena: “I recommend that the state keep the rule.” (recommend)

4 What do you think?

A sua opinião

Finish the sentence with your own opinion.

Não existe resposta certa. Use a estrutura do começo.

Example Start with: If voting were optional,...

Diga o que você acha que aconteceria, com let, make ou want + pessoa.

If voting were optional, I wouldn't let my kids skip it.

YOUR TURN · agora é você

1 Start with: I'd like the government to...

2 Start with: The state shouldn't make...

3 Start with: I suggest that...

5 Take a side

Para a conversa em sala

Choose a side. Note two arguments of your own.

Escolha um lado e anote dois argumentos seus antes da conversa.

FOR · A FAVOR

The state should make people vote

- It forces politicians to listen to everyone.
- It doesn't let a small, angry minority decide.
- It protects poorer citizens, who stay home first.

Useful: **It makes politicians...** · **I don't want a minority to...** · **Look at Chile:**

AGAINST · CONTRA

People should be free to stay home

- Freedom includes the freedom not to take part.
- Forcing people to vote produces random votes.
- The state should teach people, not push them.

Useful: **Nobody should make me...** · **I'd like the state to...** · **I suggest that...**

MY ARGUMENTS · meus argumentos

Telling people what to do

Three families. The person always comes right after the verb.

1 verb + person + to

want · would like · ask · tell · advise · warn · force · expect

O "não" entra antes do to: **not to**.

The coach **told** us **to** arrive early.

My doctor **advised** me **not to** skip breakfast.

2 let / make / have + person + verb

Sem to. O verbo fica na base.

Na pergunta, só o auxiliar muda.

Our manager **let** us leave at four.

Does the school **make** students wear a uniform?

3 suggest / recommend + that + person + verb

O verbo fica na base, sem -s, mesmo com he / she.

Não existe ~~suggest him to~~.

The lawyer **suggested that** she **sign** the contract today.

I **recommend that** he **take** the train.

Self-check

Marque o que você já consegue fazer

☐ I can follow a news article about politics and find the facts.

Consigo acompanhar uma matéria sobre política e achar os fatos.

☐ I can ask what someone lets, makes or wants people to do.

Consigo perguntar com let, make e want + pessoa.

☐ I can report what people told, asked or warned others to do.

Consigo contar o que alguém pediu, disse ou avisou para outra pessoa fazer.

☐ I can give my opinion with I'd like... to and I suggest that...

Consigo dar minha opinião com I'd like... to e I suggest that...